

Q: Are you focusing on a specific segment at this event?

A: At Open Source India, we aren't limiting ourselves to just one specific segment. This year marks our first attendance as Code and Theory, and our primary goal is to ensure that we are both visible and audible. We want to engage with key leaders across various sectors, including startups and enterprise segments, to understand their current challenges and problems. We aim to explore how we can collaborate effectively, not just in the realm of open source but also as strategic partners. We're open to various opportunities for collaboration and partnership across different sectors, looking to understand and address the diverse needs present in the tech industry today.

Q: Which industry segments do you engage with the most?

A: Our engagement isn't limited to a specific industry. We see a diversified range of responses from various sectors. However, there's a clear inclination towards cloud and AI-based components, aligning with the general progression of the tech industry. Since the beginning, we have worked with a broad spectrum, including data analytics and machine learning (ML), focusing on enhancing user experience.

Q: How do you manage your products' maintenance and bug fixing?

A: Managing maintenance and bug fixing involves a cost in terms of resources and time. However, the role of community collaboration makes this process exciting and effective. We often receive input and contributions from community members who suggest improvements or offer enhancements they have already implemented. We also get requests from users to fix specific bugs or defects in our components.

Setting up a dedicated vertical for managing this process is essential. We invest time in maintaining and updating what we've built and released to the community, ensuring our products remain functional, efficient, and relevant.

Q: Does that compromise on profitability?

A: I don't believe it comes at the cost of profitability. When we establish an active vertical or a specialised focus, we consciously allocate a portion of our investment towards it, but with a strategic goal in mind. This investment is not aimed at direct financial returns from the open source projects but rather at leveraging them for different revenue streams and supporting a team dedicated to building, maintaining, and expanding these open source tools.

As we grow and contribute more significantly to the open source community, we gain recognition as consumers and as creators of solid software that the world can use. This reputation helps attract clients who trust us for open source projects and building their business-critical software. Our open source involvement demonstrates our ability to write code that earns widespread trust. As more and more companies use our open source software, it builds confidence in our ability to handle complex software projects.

Q: You mentioned mission-critical systems as a target segment. Could you elaborate?

A: Consider a healthcare application where you need to display healthcare information to an end user. To construct such an interface, multiple components are required. These could range from user interface elements to more complex data processing modules. In such scenarios, we could use existing open source components to develop features that display healthcare information to the end user. This speeds up the development process and ensures reliability by using tried and tested components.

Our component development isn't limited to just user-facing elements. We also focus on backend components that might not be directly visible to the end user but are crucial for the system's functionality. For example, in content management systems like Drupal, we contribute to the visible and underlying aspects of these systems. Our contribution spans an end-to-end spectrum, catering to critical systems' visible and invisible components.

Q: Is it justified to use open source in critical systems with respect to reliability, security and safety?

A: Yes, using open source in critical systems can be justified, mainly due to the principles of collaboration and resilience at the heart of open source. Open source software, being contributed to and improved upon by a broad community, tends to be trustworthy and reliable. In the context of mission-critical systems, it's common to use open source components as a foundation. These foundational elements are then built upon with proprietary systems to enhance security and address specific needs. While you might not see open source components used directly in highly specialised applications like automated braking systems, they often underpin such systems. Open source solutions, solidly tested and used by a broad community, provide a reliable base that companies can build upon. This can save significant time, cutting off months or even years of development.

Q: What is your advice to those just entering this space in the open source domain?

A: For those delving into open source, there are several important aspects to consider.

It's crucial to have clear leadership support and alignment. This involves having a clear vision and a well-defined execution strategy. Begin with small steps. Adopt a 'crawl, then walk, then